In reality, however, its governance record shows that beneath the surround sound of Hinduness lies a concerted focus on creating a targeted social welfare net. That is why it is crucial to examine the BJP's foundational economic idea of 'swadeshi' (home-made) and the inherent contradiction this may have with the forces of economic liberalisation. This chapter shows how the party negotiated these pulls and pressures as it melded its governance aims with its electoral ambitions.

The idea of the BJP as an Indian Thatcherite or Reagan-type right-wing economic reform party was always a simplistic view, belied by the party's own history and evolution. As Vinay Sahasrabuddhe, the BJP's vice president, told me over a dinner meeting in Delhi, 'We are *not* right-wing in the traditional sense in economic terms. What we are pursuing can be labelled as a mixed economy. So, we are never capitalist, and of course we are not socialist. This label that we are a right-wing party is not acceptable. Neither is it a factual description of us.' Sahasrabuddhe was not only a Rajya Sabha MP, he was party vice-president at the time, chairman of the Indian Council for Cultural Relations and also headed the BJP's Department of Policy Research and its Department of Good Governance. He ran the BJP's Training Cell for over a decade, and remains a key moving force behind the Rambhau Mhalgi Prabodhini. As such, his views are an important insight into party's thinking on policies. When I asked him if, in economic terms alone, it was a misnomer to call the BJP a right-wing party, he replied, 'absolutely'. How does the BJP define its economic positioning? As 'centrist', he responded.

So, does the BJP stand for free markets in the way that American Republicans or the British Conservatives have traditionally done? 'I repeat the remark by the economist Vijay Tendulkar who said that that the prefixes of left and right have lost their meaning,' he replied. It is a comment that flies in the face of the traditional understanding of the BJP. As Sahasrabuddhe said, 'This misunderstanding is across the world. Unlike in India, there is a constituency perhaps in certain parts of the world which cherishes the idea of being a rightist. We are not like that. For example, in India, political correctness drives you to "tom-tom" leftism because